

Letters to Forum Editor

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FORUM

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H11

REACTIONS TO PM LEE'S NATIONAL DAY RALLY SPEECH

Three years away but still part of S'pore family

I JUST returned from Japan after a three-year stint as an English teacher under the Japan Exchange and Teaching Programme.

After touching down at Changi Airport on Aug 14, I felt a sense of warmth and security. I was greeted with a smile (and I duly returned one) at the Customs and passed it without a glitch.

At the money changer, I was greeted with more smiles. I changed my yen and the attendants responded with many "thank-you"s. I smiled and left, feeling satisfied.

I went to Kovan, Compasspoint and Hougang malls to run some errands in the last few days. So much has

changed! Shops have been relocated and even the toilets are much cleaner now.

When I couldn't find my way to a couple of places, I went to the customer service for assistance. On all occasions I was again greeted with smiles and "thank-you"s and was promptly led to my destination. I never felt so at home.

On Friday, I got into a taxi (SHB973B), headed for the Japanese Association. Along the way, I had a fabulous chat with the friendly driver (a Mr Kim, if I am not mistaken) and he could not stop calling me "sir". I told him that was unnecessary but he responded with "It's basic courtesy. I have been addressed

as 'sir' even at McDonald's. This is how service should really be." (I wished I had given him a tip.)

Listening to the Rally speech by Prime Minister Lee Hsien Loong on Sunday night, I could not help but clap.

While working in Japan, I registered with the Singapore Embassy in Tokyo. In August 2003, we were warmly welcomed by the embassy staff and had dinner with the staff. After a rather-severe earthquake in October 2004, I received an e-mail and a call from the embassy staff to check if I was fine.

I faced an unexpected problem at Haneda Airport before leaving for Guam last December. I called the emergency number at the embassy and received immediate assistance late at night (Thank you, Geraldine).

In April, I was also given

full assistance, this time to register as an overseas elector, and successfully voted for the first time in Tokyo.

I would like to thank all the embassy staff in Tokyo for their assistance in the last three years (and more to come...).

I already feel very much at home, after being away for three years, though not a really long time. I am really glad that the Singapore "family" abroad has not been forgotten. I hope it will remain so always.

I have found a new, long-term job in Japan and I will be leaving for Tokyo in mid-September.

I will fondly remember PM Lee's Rally speech, that the overseas Singapore family is always on the minds of the leadership.

It is unlikely that I "would stay away forever".

Tan Eng Seng

ONLINE FORUM

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Look beyond academic qualifications to find local talents

PM Lee connects well with young S'poreans in his N-Day Rally speech

Create more opportunities for S'poreans to excel in science, business and the arts

S'poreans pay price for not heeding Govt's plea for more babies

When police will act on a non-seizable offence

I REFER to the letters by Dr Vincent Chia Wei Meng ("When does an assault become a criminal case?") and Mr Daniel Chan Wai Piew ("Implications on public security troubling") in The Straits Times on Aug 17.

The offence of voluntarily causing hurt under Section 323 of the Penal Code is a non-seizable offence.

The key difference between a seizable and a non-seizable offence is that for seizable offences (such as murder, rape, voluntarily causing grievous hurt or causing hurt with weapons), police officers are legally empowered to arrest without a warrant. For non-seizable offences (such as misappropriation of property and mischief), police require a warrant of arrest or an order from a magistrate to make an arrest.

Section 323 cases can range from a parent disciplining his child by slapping him, to family disputes, to scuffles between quarrelling persons, to bullying cases arising from road rage or a staring incident.

Many of the cases reported under Section 323 arose between adults in situations of dispute which get out of hand and the parties get into a fight. Most family-related cases are resolved amicably without police intervention. These parties often do not necessarily want to seek redress through the legal system.

Dr Chia expressed concern over the safety of his family and friends following the assault on Dr Liew. He also asked if members of the public should call the police if they witnessed assaults.

Police investigation showed that Dr Liew was assaulted by two persons at a deserted back lane near a coffee shop. When he returned to the coffee shop and members of the public noticed he was injured, they called the police,

POLICE'S ASSURANCE TO PUBLIC

Police would like to assure the public that in cases where there is clear harm to public interests and vulnerable victims, even where the offence may turn out to be a non-seizable one, police will seek powers to lawfully investigate and prosecute the offender.

not realising that he had already done so. Police investigators pursued the information given by Dr Liew but he was not able to identify the alleged assailants.

The public should continue to report such incidents. When alerted, police will respond and step in to prevent an incident from escalating in the public place, and ensure that public peace is restored.

When a report of voluntarily causing hurt that has occurred and stopped is received, police officers respond and go down to the scene to establish the preliminary facts